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GI news

Goodbye Glenrock



Colin Tiernan photos

Danaher resident Walt Peterson finishes loading his belongings as he prepares to leave the home he has owned for 20 years.

By Colin Tiernan
Staff Reporter

The sky above Glenrock is an unbroken sheet of bright gray. It's 30-something degrees and raining, and Walt Peterson stands in a puddle in front of the house he has owned for 20 years, his sneakers half submerged in water, wearing a T-shirt. His hands are busy fastening a tarp, which is covering his family's possessions, all loaded in a trailer attached to his Jeep.

Peterson grew up in Glenrock. He's a Herder through and through, class of '89. This town has been his home for pretty much his whole life, but with the Danaher trailer park on Platte Street being cleared off and the lots sold, that's about to change. Priced out of Glenrock and Wyoming, with nowhere else to turn, the Petersons are heading to Alabama.

"Basically we're losing everything," Walt says.

PRICED OUT

Being forced to leave is a hardship for every family at the Danaher mobile home park, but it's especially difficult for Walt and Stefanie Peterson and their two children. For years Walt worked as a safety manager in the oilfields and taught truck driving. He took pride in his work, and the pay was good. These days, health issues make it nearly impossible for Walt to hold a job, and it's a challenge to pay the bills with Stefanie's paycheck as a Union Pacific ride coordinator.

"I've had seven heart attacks," Walt explained. "We got a little behind, made house payment arrangements, and then everything was cut out from underneath us."

The Petersons aren't the only residents of the trailer park with their backs against the wall. Several families are leaving Glenrock, in part because so little housing is available in town. For those lucky enough to have the money to move their trailers, it's a battle to find locations to reset mobile homes in the municipal limits.

"We can't afford to live here," Walt said. "I've blown my entire savings trying to save this place. I've got nothing left."

Doris Gosnell has lived at the park since 1974. She used to own a ceramics store next to the old barbershop in town. Her husband passed away two years ago. Now she lives alone. Almost alone.

"Just me and my dog," she said with a smile.

Gosnell isn't overly emotional about her situation, saying she has few, if any, fond memories of living in the trailer park. She talks about the situation in a thoroughly matter-of-fact manner, explaining she'll be moving to either Douglas or Casper.

"We just gotta move," she said. "Not much we can do about it."

Carol McCrary is in a better position than many of her neighbors, but getting her home off of the lot is going to be a challenge. And, the past couple of months have been stressful.

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A fishy field trip

Students head to a hatchery



Cinthia Stimson photos

Glenrock Intermediate School sixth grader James Vanas checks out the temperature of the water in a fiberglass trough at Dan Speas Fish Hatchery.

By Cinthia Stimson
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As school in Glenrock wraps up for the year, the last few days are final exams, field trips and fun for students and their teachers – but something in the air was a little bit fishy for Sally Down's sixth grade class recently.

Despite the spring snow that steadily fell over Converse County, Glenrock's 55 sixth graders were treated to an end-of-year field trip to the Dan Speas Fish Hatchery 15 miles outside of Casper on the morning of May 22.

Speas is a production hatchery – incubating and hatching eggs until

Please see Hatchery, page A-6



Pat Fulton photos

Glenrock Police Department Chief David Theel speaks during the Memorial Day ceremony.

Honoring the fallen on Memorial Day

By Pat Fulton
Independent Staff

Residents and veterans of Glenrock came together to honor those who paid the ultimate sacrifice Monday at the Glenrock Cemetery for Memorial Day. Pastor Rick Bishop led the ceremony in prayer, while Crissie Wobig shared a poetry reading to the crowd in honor of those who served.

"My husband served in Vietnam. He was able to come back and is buried up here now," Wobig said. "I think it is important to honor him and those he

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Goodbye

From the Front Page



Walt Peterson secures his belongings under a tarp prior to moving away from his Danaher mobile home park residence May 9.

"It just turns your life upside down," she said. "It's taken a big chunk out of our savings."

McCrary is one of a handful who were able to find a place for their trailers in town, but even the under-two-mile trip to Brubaker Road is going to cost her — between the trailer move, electrical and HVAC hookups — about $5,000.

Several mobile home owners simply can't come up with that kind of money and will have to leave their homes where they're sitting, even though they have been told they will be sued if they fail to clear their lots. Some owners have already left. Their homes eerily silent, forlorn. Some propped up by cinder blocks.

"A lot of these people here are going to have to walk away from everything they own," Walt said. "And they'll probably get sued later because all this stuff's here."

Hummer Wickett, husband of trailer park owner Twink Wickett, said at a town council meeting in April that some tenants could possibly leave their lots, then purchase one of the 10 lots that will be sold There are currently 14 lots.

Leaving the trailer park and coming back isn't an option for many though, for two main reasons. First, the price would be excessive, assuming a mobile home owner could find a place to set their trailer while the lots are being cleared, re-sized and prepped. Second, the Town of Glenrock isn't particularly friendly to mobile home owners. By town law, trailers built before 1996 can't be set in the town limits. That means mobile home owners with trailers older than 22 years old simply can't stay in town. None of the five families and individuals the Independent interviewed are returning to the trailer park.

Teanna Hill is a single mother who has lived at the trailer park for about a year. Because of the town's pre-1996 policy, she'll be moving to county land, which she's unhappy about — she loves living close to town.

Since she was informed she'd have to clear out back in April, she's been anxious.

"It's stressing me out," she said. "What am I going to do, where am I going to go?"

Hill isn't pleased with how the owners have handled the situation. She said that in order to afford moving her home she had to start saving money, which meant she couldn't afford her rent. Now the owners are taking her to collections.

"It's like, 'Do you want me to move my trailer, or do you want your lot rent?'" she said.



Teanna Hill, a single mother, has to move out of Glenrock entirely, because her mobile home was built before 1996. Glenrock does not allow owners homes to set their homes in town limits if they are more than 23 years old, so Hill is moving into the county.

BAD TIMING

The owners of the trailer park on Platte Street announced their plans to clear the area and sell the lots at a town council meeting April 8. The council voiced their approval of the proposal, voted in favor of it, and indicated it would be a welcome improvement and would clean-up the area. No town official voiced concerns about impacts to the 14 families that call the trailer park home.

Residents at the park expressed anger and frustration that they were only given the legal minimum 120 days notice, four months warning before the June 30 deadline.

"I think it's B.S.," home owner Ken Durbin said.

"They knew about this months and months ago. They didn't say nothing," McCrary said. "All of us feel the same way. If we had been given eight months, instead of four months notice, things would have been entirely different."

On top of that, the town is re-building water lines under Platte Street within the next two weeks, so mobile home owners' effective move out date is either this week or next. The back alley is unlikely to work for removing long, cumbersome trailers, so getting out before construction is a must.

The short notice caused other problems, too. McCrary explained that when she discovered she'd have to move, she looked into buying a house in town. Realtors told her that had she reached out sooner, homes might have been available, but properties have been snatched up as hundreds of workers flock to Converse County to work in the oilfields and its ancillary industries.

Wickett has considered making the change for several years, for several reasons, and admitted she perhaps should have given tenants more notice. The town's lack of certainty regarding the Platte Street water line work made planning difficult, she said.

She explained that the reason she's selling the property is that she doesn't want to have to pass it on to her children. She also said that the trailer park has been difficult to keep clean and she has had difficulty collecting rent.

Those realities don't mean the decision was an easy one. The owner admits the situation has given her sleepless nights.

"We don't like it," Wickett said. "We feel really horrible. We wish them the best of luck."

The Petersons and several other mobile home owners emphasized that they hold no ill will toward the Wickett/Danaher family. They wish they'd been given more notice, but also recognize the property owner's right to sell.

CAN'T CATCH A BREAK

One option that had been available a year ago evaporated in April. The Glenrock Area Solid Waste Disposal District stopped accepting mobile homes then. Several homeowners suggested they would have likely taken their homes to the waste disposal district had the offering not been cut.

Waste disposal district manager Crystal Stoldt said that the decision to stop accepting mobile homes was not an effort to avoid taking on Danaher trailer park mobile homes. The district had been considering making the switch for more than a year.

Another headache for mobile homes owners is that mobile homes aren't particularly mobile. Severe damage in transit, even for short trips, isn't uncommon. For those who can afford to move their trailer, and the lucky ones who found a place to set their trailer and could hire a company to move it, there's still the problem of weather. This year's unusually wet spring means that moving trailers has been nearly impossible until the ground dries out.

PUSHING PEOPLE OUT?

Wyoming Community Development Authority Executive Director Lesli Wright said that situations like the one at the Danaher trailer park aren't uncommon for communities going through a minerals-fueled economic spike.

"I think it's unfortunately more common than you think," she said. "It typically centers around when the energy industry is in a boom."

Mobile home owners typically have very little power under the best circumstances. Their homes don't tend to hold their value very well, and they rent the land under their feet. But property owners find themselves in an advantageous position during booms.

"Unfortunately (people being forced out) is a by-product of good economic times," Wright said.

The problem is a nationwide one, and in comparison to some major cities, Wyoming's affordable housing situation isn't that bad. Still, in Converse County especially these days, housing is tight.

"With the boom-and-bust cycles, people are hesitant to build enough supply," Wright said, pointing to Gillette, Wright, Pinedale and now Converse County. "It's a big problem . . . What typically happens is you see man camps open up."

A FRESH START

Stefanie Peterson did her best to stay positive about what might be the most challenging ordeal she has ever faced. Like her husband Walt, Stefanie grew up in Glenrock and graduated from Glenrock High School. This has been her home, but now Alabama, where she has family, is her best option.

"Maybe it's what we need for a fresh start," she said. "Maybe it's the worst thing that can happen."

"The town doesn't make it easy on a person like this," Walt said.

"Never will."



Come celebrate Gary and Mary Boldt's 50th Anniversary!
Our parents would love for you to come help them celebrate!
Open House social on June 1st from 1:00-4:00 p.m.
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